Chapter One

It was the best of times, it was the worst of times, it was the age of wisdom, it was the age of foolishness, it was the epoch of belief, it was the epoch of incredulity, it was the season of Light, it was the season of Darkness.

Everyone has a skeleton in the closet, and Mr. Lorry was no exception. He had spent years keeping a stiff upper lip while the bank’s affairs went south. By the skin of his teeth, he had avoided the long arm of the law.

The weather was dreadful; nevertheless, the carriage pressed on through the mud, its lanterns flickering like fireflies in a jar. Nobody spoke a word.

Chapter Two

"Break a leg," she whispered, although nobody was going on stage. The idiom had become a private joke between them, a shorthand for courage in the face of ordinary mornings.

He shrugged. "It’s not rocket science," he said, "but it isn’t a piece of cake either." The kettle whistled. Outside, the fog rolled in from the river like a slow tide of milk.

Serendipity, she thought, is just coincidence that decided to be kind.

Chapter Three

The committee met on a Tuesday, which everyone agreed was the most forgettable day of the week. Minutes were taken; hours were lost.

At the eleventh hour, a compromise emerged: they would table the motion until spring, a phrase that meant opposite things on either side of the Atlantic, and so pleased everyone for entirely different reasons.